and the ministry of road transport and highways of India to improve connectivity through all means, as well as with the ministry of external affairs to ease visa procedures. "There are 160 countries whose travellers can now apply for an e-visa to India," says Singh.

Synergy between key stakeholders is a new focus area, especially in public-private partnership. In Odisha, for example, the state tourism department has identified three roles for itself—being an enabler for infrastructure, promoting investments and viewing tourism as an industry. "Earlier, investors did not have confidence in Konark. Now, after we launched the Eco Retreat, we have had six proposals from 5-star hotels for the same area. The state should woo the investor, the investor will bring tourists," says Sachin Jadhav, director of the Odisha tourism department. He adds that a lack of industrial and tourism literacy is to blame for hiccups in public-private cooperation because for long, states did not fully understand tourism or their role in it.

Things have certainly improved, says Aman Nath, founder and chairman of Neemrana Hotels. Nath was among the first to sign a public-private partnership agreement for hotels in Rajasthan. He notes how the industry is easier to navigate today compared to decades ago, when it took his hotel 22 years to just get electricity and bureaucratic hurdles made things tough. "Some things have indeed changed. In the last month, I have heard from Madhya Pradesh tourism, Uttar Pradesh tourism. They had impossible terms earlier but now they are very clear in their expectations," says Nath. For him—and other investors—there are a few basic demands that states must meet for projects to get started, the most critical being road, water and electricity. "If a state thinks they can be smart in troubling you, then we just turn our back and go to the next one. PPP has to mean 'public-private partnership'. So far, it has meant private party's problem," he says. "The private and public sectors should drop the 'we' and 'they' line and do it together."

Abhay Singh, secretary, Bihar tourism department, adds, "Land is needed by investors and the state can play a role here to ensure that they don't get cheated. This is a time to act together." Sandeep Nanduri, director of the Tamil Nadu tourism department and managing director of the Tamil Nadu Tourism Development Corporation, agrees. "The state's role in building infrastructure is important. People are short of time, they want to immediately reach a place and experience its beauty. The state can also be an enabler in developing good hotels," he says. Notably, the Rajasthan government has already embarked on such a synergic path. "The state has focused on the ease of doing business. In the last year, we processed 762 applications from small businesses as they will add fresh air and value to tourism in the state," says Gayatri Rathore, principal secretary, Rajasthan tourism department.

In a post-Covid world, the tourism sector has to adapt to new expectations. "Tourism in



"Inbound tourism has picked up and domestic tourism has seen tremendous growth. New spots where tourism infrastructure has been built up are witnessing growth"

ARVIND SINGH
Secretary, Ministry of Tourism



"Tourism in India is connected to a few big cities, but with physical connectivity and a growing economy, we need to push tourism down to the last mile. This will usher in the next tourism revolution"

PARAMESWARAN IYER
Executive Director, World Bank



"Tourists don't want to go to known destinations. People are really keen about homestays and natural spaces, much more than hotels in congested towns"

HARSHWARDHAN CHAUHAN
Industries Minister, Himachal Pradesh



"We have diversified our tourism circuits so that people come to visit different parts of the state and can see how old our civilisation and culture are"

SATPAL MAHARAJ
Tourism Minister, Uttarakhand